THROW NO STONES AT SHEESH MAHAL

Jagan had meant it as an opulent camp office. Now it will be a deluxe resort, and maybe a museum to hubris



GRAND VIEW The Rushikonda complex in Visakhapatnam

ANI

Thus, painted in the white of his minimalistic white shirts, the Rushikonda complex could have even rivalled the White House. But fate had other plans. Jagan never managed to stay in this gigantic sea-facing residence, which came up behind secretive barricades and was quietly inaugurated in February 2024. The full durbar move was slated for after election. But Jagan's "sheeshmahal" itself became a hot topic during the campaign before he came a cropper in the May polls. Its opulence—Italian marble, gold-toned bath fittings, exotic bath tubs and commodes—came to light thereafter.

And its fate has been hanging in the balance ever since. Having cornered Jagan and his party over the fiscal 'white hole', the Naidu administration has been scratching its collective head on how to best use the complex. Adding to the complication are complaints it was built in violation of CRZ clearances and environmental norms, with the picturesque Rushikonda hill partially wrecked for it. As the debate raged, the aired suggestions included repurposing the complex as a museum, a conference hub, even a mental asylum! (The last being a satirical proposal from Goa governor and former Union minister Pusapati Ashok Gajapathi Raju, who knows a thing or two about palace estates, having grown up as a scion of the last Maharaja of Vizianagaram.) Some others recalled how, in 2019, Jagan had demolished Naidu's own Praja Vedika—a Rs 9 crore convention hall built as an extension of his residence on the Krishna's banks at Undavalli near Amaravati—and prescribed the same SOP for Rushikonda.

As the government dragged its feet, officials say the complex totted up a monthly bill of Rs 12-15 lakh for basic upkeep—with zero utility. In contrast, the state-run Haritha Resort that was demolished in 2021 to make way for it, popular and in perfect shape, was earning Rs 7.5 crore a year. A cabinet sub-committee that Naidu constituted last year has now decided to rededicate it to the hospitality sector.

Takeaways

- **The Rs 450 cr. complex has stood idle since Jagan's 2024 election defeat**
- **The Naidu govt bets on a PPP model to recover value**
- **But environmental concerns continue to shadow the project's future**

HOTELIERS CHECK IN

Its minister-members Payyavula Keshav (finance), Kandula Durgesh (tourism) and Veeranjaneya Swamy (social welfare) inspected the palace in mid-June. "We have to go for the PPP mode, so the APTDC also earns some revenue. We will discuss the proposal with hospitality majors," says Kandula. Rushikonda's interiors, more magnificent than many premium star hotels in India, should find takers. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Kandula says top names like Leela, Taj et al have shown interest. "There are some challenges, like how to utilise the vast, extravagant rooms that Jagan built for himself," he adds. "Also, the CRZ norms that will debar further construction—a disincentive for hoteliers. We need to address these aspects."

At the same time, the Naidu regime appears keen to showcase Jagan's splurge of public money to the public! So Kandula says a part of the complex may be developed as a public museum. If it could be turned to verse, it would make for quite an ironic epic. ■